

REFILL

a short film

*"What does your behaviour say about you
when nobody is watching?"*

Screenplay

LOGLINE

In a college hostel where workers keep the water running and the corridors clean without anyone noticing, an ordinary, mildly careless student slowly learns that who he is has nothing to do with who's watching – and everything to do with the small mess he chooses not to leave behind.

CENTRAL THEME

Character is not performance. It is revealed in the ordinary, unwitnessed choices we make toward people who can never repay us – a spill wiped up, a bin used instead of the floor, a "good morning" that costs nothing. The film never says this out loud. It only shows it, twice, so the audience feels the distance travelled.

CHARACTERS

ARJUN, 20 – Protagonist

Second-year engineering student. Not cruel, not lazy by nature – just unobservant, the way most people his age are about anyone who isn't a peer. Phone in hand more than not. Leaves things where they fall because someone always seems to deal with it. Has a roommate's easy charm. Nothing about him needs fixing in an obvious way, which is the point – he is every student in the audience.

KARTHIK, 20 – Arjun's Roommate

Arjun's mirror. Funny, likeable, generous with his friends – and utterly unchanged across the film. He is not a villain; he's a control group. By Act 3 the gap between him and Arjun does the film's talking.

DEVA, 50s – Water-Can and Corridor Worker

Refills the drinking-water cans every morning, mops the corridor, empties the bins. Economical with words, not with presence – hums old film songs under his breath, keeps a small transistor radio clipped to his cart tuned to cricket commentary, knows exactly which room's tap drips. Never a martyr, never pitiable. A man doing a job, well, on his own terms.

SELVI, 40s – Restroom and Housekeeping Staff

Handles the washrooms on Arjun's floor. Brisk, no-nonsense, allergic to being thanked in the performative way students sometimes do right in front of a warden. Two small scenes, no melodrama.

SETTINGS

A modest college hostel – three floors, exposed corridors, a drinking-water point with steel cans and a hand pump, common washrooms, a common room with a TV nobody agrees on, a waste disposal point near the back gate. Shot practically, on real locations, in available light.

STORY SYNOPSIS

Arjun moves through hostel life the way most students do – barely registering the people who keep it running. Water appears in his room's can. The washroom is clean when he wants it and dirty behind him. Someone always sweeps up. He isn't unkind; he simply doesn't look.

A small, unremarkable incident – a spilled water can outside his room that he steps around rather than deals with, and later sees Deva silently mopping up – lodges itself in him more than he expects. It isn't guilt exactly. It's the first time he actually sees the work happening.

Over the following days, in small and sometimes reversed steps, Arjun starts noticing what he never had to: a tap left running, a bin two steps further than the floor, a name he never asked for. He doesn't become a saint. He forgets, backslides, gets it half-right. But something in how he moves through these ordinary spaces starts to shift.

The film closes late one night, in an empty corridor with no one around to see – where Arjun makes one small, complete choice that costs him nothing to skip and nothing to be praised for. The camera lingers on the empty corridor a beat too long, and then, at dawn, on the person who never finds out he did it.

SCREENPLAY

ACT ONE – OBSERVATION

1 EXT. HOSTEL ENTRANCE – MORNING

Establishing. A three-storey hostel building, paint fading at the edges in an honest, lived-in way. Students stream in and out – earphones in, bags half-zipped, one boy eating a vada on the move.

At the gate, DEVA (50s, wiry, sun-creased) wheels in a cart loaded with steel water cans. Nobody holds the gate for him. He doesn't expect them to. He nudges it open with his hip, practiced, unbothered.

SOUND: Morning hostel ambience – scooters, distant mess-hall clatter, a cricket radio commentary very faint from Deva's cart, a bell for breakfast.

CAMERA: Wide static shot holding the entrance as the day's first traffic passes both ways through it – students going out, Deva coming in – establishing two currents that don't really see each other.

2 INT. HOSTEL CORRIDOR / WATER POINT – MORNING

A steel water point at the end of the corridor – a big drum, a tap, a row of empty cans waiting. Deva sets down a full can, swaps it for an empty one, wipes the tap dry with a cloth he keeps for exactly that.

ARJUN (20, hoodie, phone in hand) walks up, fills his bottle without looking at Deva, walks off mid-scroll. A small splash of water hits the floor from his overfull bottle. He doesn't notice.

Deva glances at the splash. Wipes it with his foot-cloth without comment. Not a big gesture – muscle memory.

CAMERA: Close-up on the overflow first, then a slow tilt up to reveal Arjun already three steps away, not looking back. This shot will be mirrored later.

3 INT. ARJUN'S ROOM – DAY

A cramped two-student room. Cricket posters, a cluttered study table, clothes on a chair doing the job of a cupboard. KARTHIK is on his bed, laughing at his phone.

KARTHIK

Bro, we're out of water again?

ARJUN

(not looking up)

Someone'll fill it.

Arjun tosses a crumpled wrapper toward the bin. It bounces off the rim and lands on the floor. Neither of them looks at it. Karthik steps

over it on his way out.

VISUAL PARALLEL SET-UP: Remember this wrapper. Its twin returns in Scene 11.

4 INT. COMMON WASHROOM – DAY

Arjun brushes his teeth at a sink, spits without rinsing it down properly, leaves a tap running while he checks his phone one-handed, then shuts it off late, almost as an afterthought. He steps out.

A beat later, SELVI enters with her cleaning cart, unfazed, part of a routine she's done a thousand times. She wipes the sink. No dialogue. No music swell. Just the shape of a job.

SOUND: Tap running a beat too long is the loudest thing in the scene – let it sit.

5 INT. HOSTEL CORRIDOR – DAY

Students lounge outside rooms – one on a phone call, two arguing amiably over a badminton bet. Deva mops past them with a bucket. A student lifts his feet without looking down, mid-conversation, purely reflexive – he'd do it for a wet floor sign too. This is not malice. This is just how invisible the routine has become.

STUDENT (O.S.)

– no yaar, deuce means deuce, both need
to touch forty!

Nobody addresses Deva. Nobody needs to. That's the whole point of Act One.

ACT TWO – REALISATION

6 INT. HOSTEL CORRIDOR – DUSK

A water can outside Arjun's door has tipped – not dramatically, just carelessly stacked earlier by someone in a hurry – and slowly leaks a thin, spreading puddle across the corridor.

Arjun steps out of his room, phone in hand as ever, sees the puddle, and steps AROUND it without breaking stride, exactly the way he'd step around a paper cup or a badminton net. He doesn't right the can. He keeps walking.

CAMERA: Track Arjun from behind at floor height, the puddle spreading in frame just past his feet – deliberately unremarkable, almost boring. The mundanity is the point.

7 INT. HOSTEL CORRIDOR – DUSK, MOMENTS LATER

Arjun, a few steps down the corridor, turns back for something he forgot – his ID card, left on the table. As he re-enters frame, he sees DEVA already crouched at the puddle, mopping it without a word, without looking up, without expecting anyone to help.

Arjun stops. Just for a second too long. Nothing is said. Deva doesn't clock him watching – this is routine to him, not a moment. For Arjun, though, something catches.

ARJUN

(quiet, almost to himself)

...sorry.

Deva looks up, mildly surprised – not because of the apology's content, but because a student said anything at all.

DEVA

(shrugs, half-smile)

It's not your can.

He goes back to mopping. Arjun doesn't know what to do with that answer. He stands there one beat too long, then walks off. No resolution yet – just a splinter.

This is the film's only real exchange of dialogue between Arjun and a worker before the final act. Keep it that plain. No music cue here – let the ambient hostel sound carry the silence.

8 INT. ARJUN'S ROOM – NIGHT

Arjun lies on his bed, phone dark on his chest, staring at the ceiling fan. Not brooding – just turning something over, the way you do with a thought too small to talk about but too stubborn to drop.

Karthik, across the room, is fully checked out – earphones in, unaffected, unaware anything happened. The gap between the two friends opens here, quietly, and will not close by the end.

9 INT. COMMON WASHROOM – DAY (LATER THAT WEEK)

Arjun brushes his teeth again – same sink, same framing as Scene 4, deliberately mirrored. He spits. Goes to leave the tap running out of habit – catches himself halfway – and shuts it off. Small. Almost accidental. He glances at his own reflection like he's not sure why he did it, then leaves.

MATCH CUT: Frame this identically to Scene 4's tap shot. Same lens, same distance. The only difference is forty-five degrees of a wrist.

10 INT. HOSTEL CORRIDOR / WATER POINT – MORNING

Arjun refills his bottle at the water point, same location as Scene 2. This time he notices Deva a few feet away, swapping cans, radio murmuring cricket scores.

ARJUN

Chennai won?

Deva glances over, mildly surprised again – a student asking him something that isn't a request.

DEVA

By six wickets. Should've been closer.

A small, real laugh from Deva. Arjun almost smiles too. Nothing more is said. Arjun caps his bottle carefully this time – no overflow. He walks off. Doesn't look back this time either – but the corridor behind him is dry.

This scene deliberately does NOT become a bonding montage. One exchange. That's enough. Overdoing it would tip into the "preachy" trap the film must avoid.

11 INT. HOSTEL CORRIDOR – DAY

Karthik tosses a wrapper at the bin near their door – the twin of Scene 3's wrapper – and it bounces off the rim exactly the same way. He doesn't notice or care; he's already walking away, laughing at something on his phone.

Arjun, a step behind him, clocks it. A half-second hesitation – caught between calling it out and letting it go, unwilling to lecture his own roommate. He says nothing. But he bends, picks up the wrapper, drops it properly in the bin, and keeps walking to catch up with Karthik like nothing happened.

IMPORTANT: Arjun does NOT comment on Karthik's littering. No moral one-upmanship, no dialogue lesson. The film trusts the visual contrast completely.

12 INT. COMMON ROOM – EVENING

A knot of students watches TV, arguing over the remote. Selvi passes through with her cart on her way out for the day, exhausted, ordinary. Most students don't register her at all.

Arjun, seated at the edge of the group, is the only one who looks up.

ARJUN

Bye, Selvi Miss.

Selvi, faintly startled that anyone used her name, nods once – not warmly, not coldly, just acknowledged – and continues out. It costs Arjun nothing. It changes nothing about his life. That's exactly the point.

CAMERA: Keep this in a wide shot, not a close-up – underplay it, don't let the frame ask for credit on Arjun's behalf.

ACT THREE – PAYOFF

13 INT. HOSTEL CORRIDOR – LATE NIGHT

Very late. The corridor lights are dimmed to the after-hours setting. Everyone is asleep or in their rooms; the building is as empty of witnesses as it will ever be. Arjun, unable to sleep, steps out for water in a T-shirt and slippers, half-awake.

At the water point, a can – the last one of the night, refilled hours ago by Deva and left slightly overbalanced on the uneven floor – has tipped on its own weight and is slowly leaking, same as Scene 6, deliberately mirrored: same angle, same puddle shape, same time-of-day emptiness.

Arjun stops. Looks at it. Looks down the corridor – empty in both directions. No one is coming. No one would ever know if he just stepped over it and went back to bed, the way he did in Scene 6.

Hold on Arjun's face for a beat longer than feels comfortable. This is the entire film compressed into one decision with no audience inside the story – only us.

He sets down his bottle. Rights the can. Uses his own T-shirt sleeve, unbothered, to wipe the worst of the spill, then grabs the mop leaning against the wall – left there by Deva, always in the same spot – and finishes the job properly, if a little clumsily. He's clearly done this for the first time.

He puts the mop back exactly where he found it. Picks up his water bottle. Walks back to his room. The corridor is empty again, dry, silent, as if nothing happened.

SOUND: No score. Only the mop, the drip, his slippers, a fan somewhere. Let the silence do the emotional work the dialogue never did.

CAMERA: Static wide shot of the empty corridor, held for a good four to five seconds after Arjun exits frame. Long enough to feel uncomfortable. This shot has no one in it – which is exactly the argument the whole film has been making.

14 INT. HOSTEL CORRIDOR / WATER POINT – DAWN, NEXT DAY

First light. DEVA arrives with his cart, same unhurried routine as the opening scene – radio murmuring, humming under his breath. He reaches the water point expecting the small end-of-night mess he always finds and quietly deals with.

He stops. The floor is already dry. The mop is back in its exact spot, slightly damp still. He looks at it for a moment – not confused exactly, more like a man noticing a small anomaly in a routine he knows better than anyone.

He glances once down the empty corridor. No one is there to ask. He doesn't need an answer. A small, private, almost-amused exhale – not quite a smile – and he goes on with his morning, setting up the cans as he always does.

Deva never learns it was Arjun. Arjun never comes back for credit. This is deliberate: the whole point is that the act doesn't need a witness to complete it. The AUDIENCE is the only one who knows both halves of this scene – which is where the film's dramatic irony, and its theme, land at the same time.

15 EXT. HOSTEL ENTRANCE – MORNING

Same gate as the opening. The same two currents – students leaving, Deva just arrived – cross again. On the surface, nothing about the hostel looks different from Scene 1. That's intentional.

Arjun exits with Karthik, laughing at something, phone half out of his pocket – visually almost identical to any student in the film, including his own earlier self.

As he passes the gate, without breaking his conversation with Karthik, he reaches out and pushes it fully open behind him instead of letting it swing half-shut on the next person – a two-second, wordless gesture, easy to miss if you're not looking for it.

He doesn't look back to see who benefits. He doesn't need to.

FADE OUT.

END TITLE CARD (no dialogue, held 3-4 seconds, plain white text on black):

"Character is what you do when no one is keeping score."

SOUND & AMBIENT AUDIO NOTES

The film carries almost no score. Music, where used at all, should be a single sparse instrument (acoustic guitar or a lone piano figure) entering only under Scene 13-14, and only faintly – the emotional beat should be earned by the visual, not underlined by the music.

Everywhere else, lean on diegetic sound: running taps, mop against tile, a distant cricket radio, hostel bells, scooters, the particular echo of an empty corridor at night. Silence is a tool here, not an absence – use it deliberately in Scenes 7, 13, and 14.

CAMERA & VISUAL LANGUAGE NOTES

- Keep the camera observational and mostly static or slow-moving in Act One – the film should feel like it's simply noticing things, the way Arjun eventually learns to.
- Use identical framing for the three mirrored pairs: the tap (Scenes 4/9), the wrapper and bin (Scenes 3/11), and the water-point puddle (Scenes 6/13). Same lens, same distance, same time of day where possible – the repetition is the film's real argument, not any line of dialogue.
- Favor close-ups on hands and small actions – a cap twisting shut, a wrapper landing, a mop returned to its spot – over close-ups on faces reacting. Let the audience read the action before the expression.
- Workers should regularly be shown mid-task, competent and unhurried, never in a posture of appeal to camera or to characters. No slow-motion, no swelling score under their appearances – that would tip them into objects of pity rather than people at work.
- The final held shot of the empty corridor (Scene 13) is the visual thesis of the film. Do not cut away from it too early.

ENDING EXPLANATION

The film deliberately withholds the one thing a lesser version of this story would reach for: a moment where Deva or Selvi finds out what Arjun did and thanks him, or where Arjun is seen and praised by his peers. Neither happens. Deva registers only that the mess wasn't there – not who prevented it. Arjun gets no in-story credit at all.

This is the mechanism of the theme, not just its illustration. The title, REFILL, works two ways by the end – the literal water cans Deva refills every day, and the quieter refilling that happens in Arjun,

unnoticed by anyone in his world, visible only to the audience watching from outside it. The final title card states the theme in eight words only after the audience has already felt it for eleven minutes without being told – earning the line rather than opening with it.

The film does not claim Arjun is transformed into a better person than everyone around him, and Karthik is left deliberately unchanged – a reminder that this story isn't about becoming exceptional. It's about one small, private, repeatable choice, made when the corridor is empty and nobody is keeping score.